

Another crack: The 2026 edition in Japan will mark Mirabai Chanu's third shot at an Asian Games medal. The Olympic silver medallist, who had withdrawn from the 2018 Asian Games due to a back injury, came fourth at the 2023 edition in Hangzhou. PICS: SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

takes a cloth and wipes off the barbell, removing the white chalk deposited from her palms over the course of dozens of lifts in the training session.

She doesn't think much of it.

"I've always done this," she tells *Sportstar* later. "I consider the barbell nothing less than the weapon a soldier carries into battle. Just like he keeps his weapon clean, I also have to maintain my equipment. I also have to be an example to younger weightlifters," she says.

Since beginning her international career in 2014, Mirabai has faced her share of challenges and built a record that will be hard to emulate.

Having already won titles at the World Championships, medals at the Asian Championships, Commonwealth Games and, of course, an Olympic silver, Mirabai has shown few signs of slowing down. Last year, she won another world medal, a silver in the women's 48kg category.

Then, at the National Championships in February this year, she lifted a Personal Best of 89kg in the snatch. She followed that with a 116kg lift in the clean and jerk to total 205kg, equalling her Personal Best recorded at the 2021 Asian Championships in the 49kg category.

Tough phase

While she is in strong form, Mirabai knows this phase will be among her toughest. Last year, the International Weightlifting Federation announced that weight categories for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics were being rejigged. The lightest women's category, 49kg, in which Mirabai has competed for most of the last decade and won silver at the Tokyo Olympics, was dropped from the Olympic programme.

She will have no choice but to move up to the 53kg division. She plans to first compete in this higher category at the 2026 Asian Games

Mirabai Chanu began her 2026 season at the National Weightlifting Championships in February and set three new national records in the women's 48kg category.

